

Arthritis in Young People – UK Guide

Arthritis doesn't just affect older adults. Learn about juvenile idiopathic arthritis (JIA) and other types affecting young people in the UK, plus where to find support.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-07 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis is often thought of as a condition affecting older adults, but in the UK, around **15,000 children and young people** are living with arthritis. Understanding the condition and accessing the right support is crucial for managing symptoms and maintaining quality of life.

Types of Arthritis in Young People

Juvenile Idiopathic Arthritis (JIA)

JIA is the most common type of arthritis in under-16s. "Idiopathic" means the cause is unknown. There are several subtypes:

- Oligoarticular JIA — affects 4 or fewer joints, most common type
- Polyarticular JIA — affects 5 or more joints
- Systemic JIA — causes whole-body symptoms including fevers and rash
- Enthesitis-related JIA — affects where tendons attach to bone
- Psoriatic JIA — associated with the skin condition psoriasis

Reactive Arthritis

Can develop after an infection and usually resolves within weeks to months.

Young Adult Onset

Rheumatoid arthritis, ankylosing spondylitis, and other inflammatory types can begin in the late teens or twenties.

Recognising Symptoms



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- Joint pain, swelling, or stiffness lasting more than 6 weeks
 - Limping or reluctance to use a limb (in younger children)
 - Morning stiffness lasting more than 30 minutes
 - Fatigue beyond normal tiredness
 - Unexplained fevers with joint symptoms
-

Getting Diagnosed in the UK

If you suspect arthritis in a child or young person:

- See your GP — describe all symptoms and how long they've lasted
 - Request a referral to a paediatric rheumatologist
 - NHS waiting times vary — ask about urgent referral if symptoms are severe
-

UK Support Resources



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- JIGSAW (Joint Involvement Group for Self-Advocacy Workshops)
- NRAS (National Rheumatoid Arthritis Society) — resources for young people

- Young people's rheumatology clinics — many NHS trusts run dedicated youth clinics
 - School support — children with JIA may qualify for an EHCP (Education, Health and Care Plan)
-

Living Well as a Young Person with Arthritis

- Stay as active as possible — swimming and cycling are excellent
- Talk to teachers and employers about reasonable adjustments
- Connect with peers online — social support reduces isolation
- Transition planning — move from paediatric to adult rheumatology services smoothly

If you're a young person with persistent joint symptoms, don't delay seeking help. Early treatment can prevent joint damage and improve long-term outcomes.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis in young people – uk guide?

Short answer: Arthritis can affect young people, with around 15,000 children and young people in the UK living with the condition. Juvenile Idiopathic Arthritis (JIA) is the most common form in under-16s, causing joint pain, swelling, and stiffness. Symptoms can include morning stiffness, fatigue, and fevers. Early diagnosis by a GP and paediatric rheumatologist is important for managing the condition.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.